

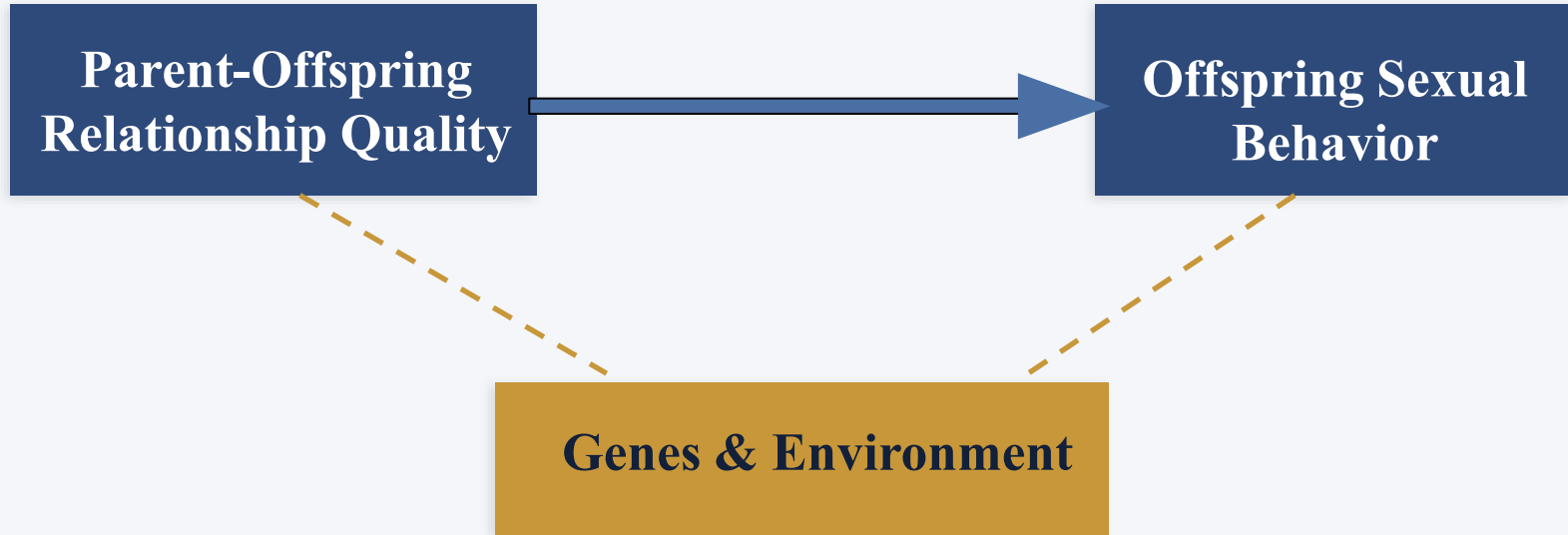
Higher Quality Parent-Offspring Relationships Predict Lower-Risk Adolescent Sexual Behavior

A Genetically Informed Sibling Comparison

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The Hypothesized Causal Model



Study Design

Minnesota Sibling Interaction and Behavior Study Dataset

- 617 two-offspring families
- 55% female
- Time 1: Parent-offspring relationship quality (M age = 17.1)
- Time 2: Offspring sexual behavior (M age = 20.6)

Family Composition

 $N = 285$ (46%)

Two adopted offspring
(0% shared genes)

 $N = 124$ (20%)

One adopted + one non-adopted
(0% shared genes)

 $N = 208$ (34%)

Two non-adopted offspring
(50% shared genes)

Parent-Offspring Relationship Quality

Composite of Four Dimensions

Conflict (12 items)

"My parent often criticizes me"

Involvement (12 items)

"I talk about my concerns with my parent"

Parent Regard (5 items)

"I know my parent loves me"

Offspring Regard (8 items)

"I respect my parent"

Multiple Reporters

Parent Reported

Average of separate mother and father reports ($r = .31$)

Offspring Reported

Average of offsprings perception of relationship with mother and father ($r = .80$)

Sexual Behavior

Sexual Behavior Inventory (SBI; 12 items)

Casual oral sex

Committed oral sex

Casual vaginal sex

Committed vaginal sex

E.g., How many different committed romantic partners have you had oral sex with in the last 12 months?

Three questions within each category: ever engaged (yes/no), number of partners in last year, lifetime numbers of partners

Single factor across all 12 items was reliable and homogenous ($u = .85$, $\omega_h = .73$, $\alpha = .93$).

Analytic Strategy: Three Lines of Evidence

1

Biometric ACE Modeling

2

Passive *r*GE Test

3

Within-Family Sibling Comparison

Prospective design reduces (but cannot eliminate) reverse causality

Shared Environment Effects

15% of the variance in offspring sexual behavior reflected shared environment effects

Best-Fitting ACE Model



A (Genetic): 32%



C (Shared Env.): 15%



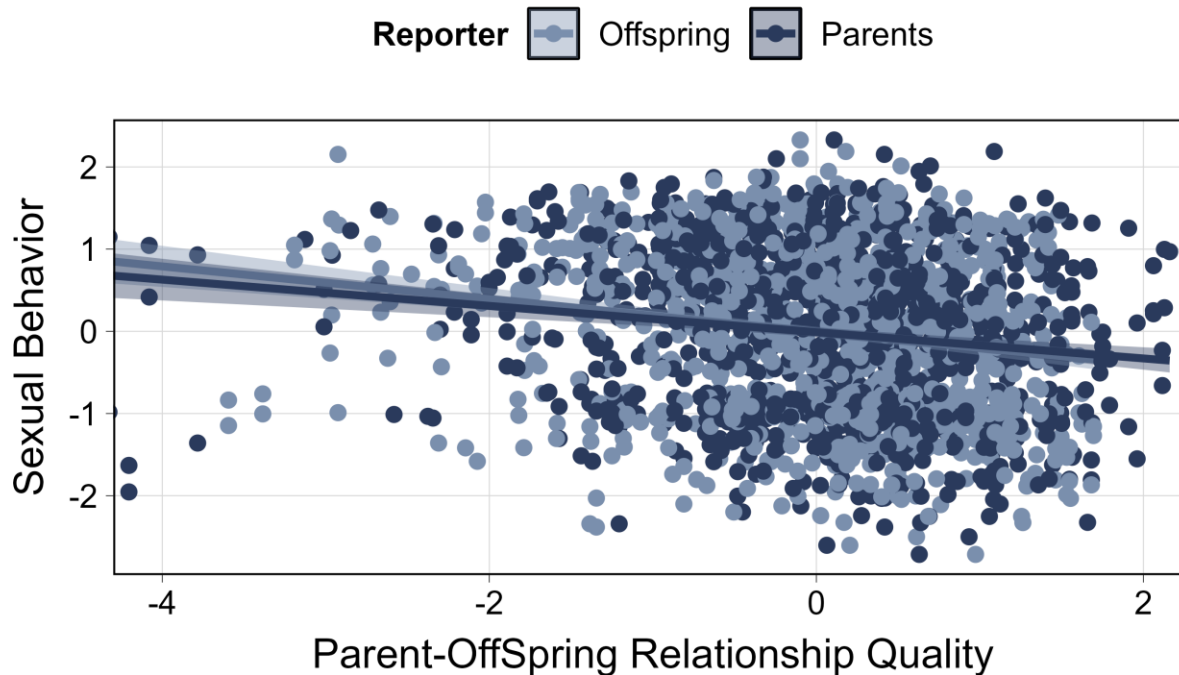
E (Non-shared): 53%

Other twin and adoptee studies also find shared environmental effects on sexual behavior

(e.g., Bricker et al., 2006; Harden & Mendle, 2011; Samek et al., 2014; Zietsch et al., 2010)

Between-Family Associations

Families with higher average parent-offspring relationship quality have offspring with lower sexual behavior



Offspring reports:

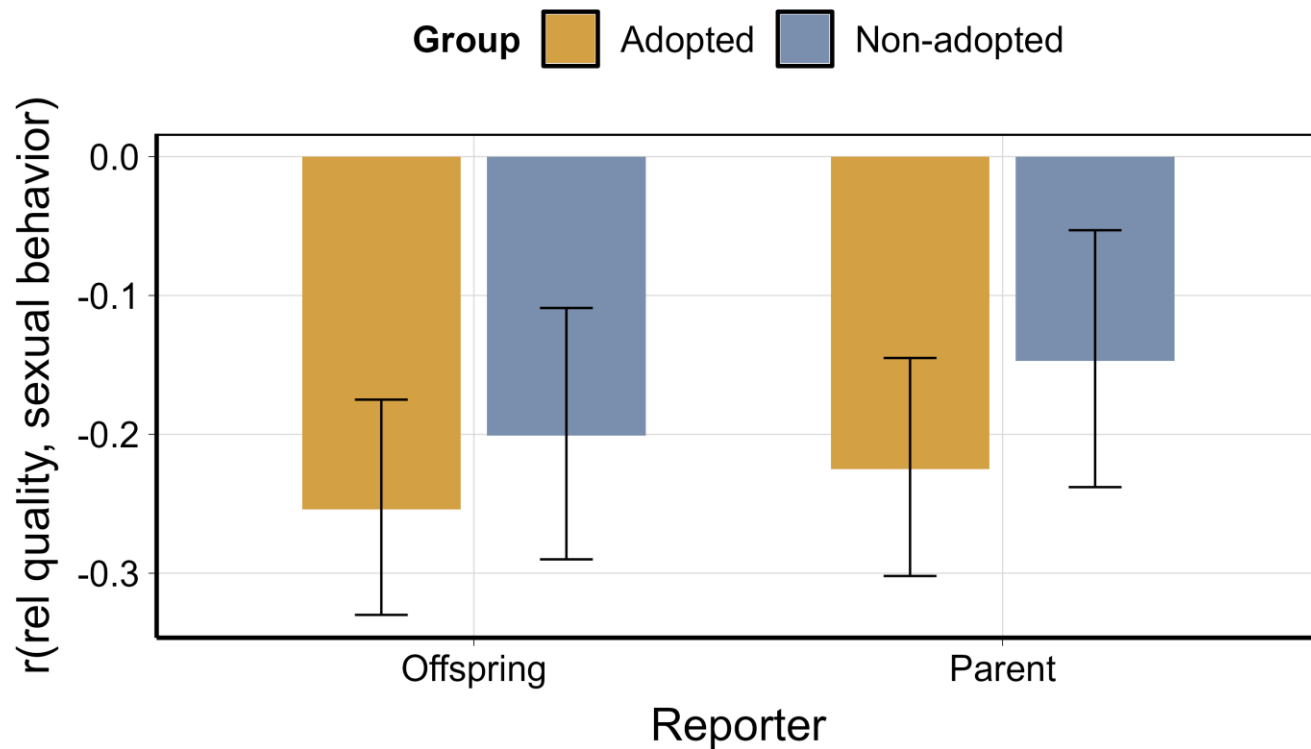
$$\beta = -0.20 [-0.27, -0.13], \\ p < .001$$

Parent reports:

$$\beta = -0.14 [-0.21, -0.08], \\ p < .001$$

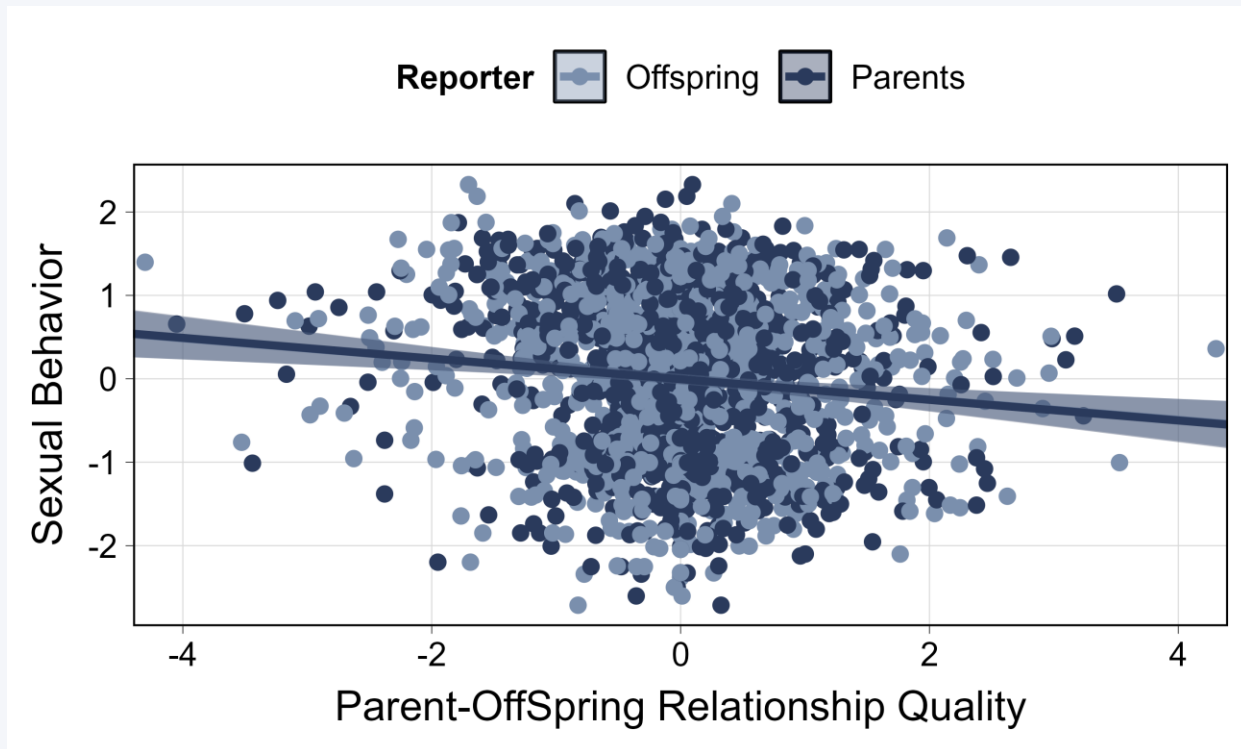
*associations are
age/sex corrected

No Passive r GE Confounding Detected



Within-Family Associations

Siblings who have a higher quality relationship with their parents have lower sexual behavior relative to their sibling.



Offspring:

$\beta = -0.12 [-0.18, -0.06]$,
 $p < .001$

Parents:

$\beta = -0.12 [-0.17, -0.06]$,
 $p < .001$

*associations are
age/sex corrected

Robustness Analyses

Results were remarkably robust to different analysis decisions

No offspring sex moderation detected

Mom and dad reports yielded consistent effects when tested separately

Consistent effects across casual and committed partner dimensions

What is the Mechanism?

Fewer sexual partners can arise through very different pathways

Pathway 1

↓ Uncommitted Sex

Better parenting reduces propensity for casual sexual encounters — fewer short-term sexual experiences overall

Pathway 2

↑ Relationship Stability

Better parenting promotes stable committed relationships — offspring cycle through fewer partners because relationships last longer

Pathway 3

Something Else?

Better mate choice?

Reduced mating effort?

Sibling dynamics?

Summary

- Better parent-offspring relationships prospectively predict fewer sexual partners
- This association is not explained by passive rGE (genetic confound)
- Within-family associations are consistent with causal environmental effect
- Results are robust to analysis decisions
- The underlying mechanism remains unknown
- Need nuanced theories that can help guide future work